

"a year" vs. "an year"

Result/Output/Answer:

"a year" = correct

"~~an year~~" = incorrect

Process:

Rule of "an" vs. "a"

"a" = used before a word starting with the **sound** of a consonant

"an" = used before a word starting with the **sound** of a vowel

Sound of "ye"

The word "year," in any version of spoken English, does not begin with the sound of a vowel.

If "year" was ever pronounced as "ear" then the word could use "an," but this appears not to be the case.

"Y" is not always a vowel.

The letter "Y" can produce an "i" [/i/] or "e" [/i(ə)/] vowel sound, but the "Ye" sound is not a vowel.

Sample phonetic versions of "year":

Wiktionary:

(RP) IPA: /jɪə/,

/jɜ:/,

SAMPA: /ji@/,

/jɜ:/;

(US) enPR: yîr,

IPA: /jɪr/,

SAMPA: /jɪr/

Merriam - Webster: \ˈyɪr\

American Heritage Dictionary of the English Language:

/yîr/

Collins English Dictionary:

/jɪə/

No "y" sounds use "an" for any other words:

The /j/ sound (in the International Phonetic Alphabet) is the same "y" sound as in:

a yak, a yolk, a yodel, a yeast packet, etc. All of which are preceded by an "a," not an "an."

Some non-native speakers cannot hear the difference between the consonant sound /j/ (as in Year, you, yesterday) and and vowel sound /i(ə)/ as in "ear" /i(ə)r/, east, end, etc. It may be more likely that non-native speakers who lack the /j/ consonant sound in their native language cannot easily hear /j/ at all, (as opposed to hearing it somehow as another class of sound). E.g. "Year" and "ear" sound the same to many non-native speakers, making it difficult to claim that the /j/ is being heard at all (unless an imaginary sound is heard preceding "ear").

Sources

Dictionaries:

Collins English Dictionary:

American Heritage Dictionary of the English Language:

Merriam-Webster:

Wiktionary:

English Grammar Websites:

forum.wordreference.com

www.englishforums.com

english.stackexchange.com

in.answers.yahoo.com

wiki.answers.com

Google Search Results, 2012,6,12:

"a year" => 1,040,000,000

"an year" => 2,290,000 [most of which are clearly mistakes]